

SOCIETY

Nolan Wells' independent autopsy says cause, manner of death 'undetermined pending investigation'

The official autopsy from the State Medical Examiner's office is not completed.

By Emily Shapiro  NEWS

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Christine and Elmore Wonsley, were desperate for answers and sent the teen's body to Washington, D.C., for the private autopsy.

A private autopsy preliminarily found that Mississippi teenager Nolan Wells' cause and manner of death are "undetermined pending investigation," with the independent pathologist acknowledging multiple limitations in the report, family attorney Ben Crump announced Wednesday, as the investigation into the 18-year-old's death continues.

Wells' parents, Christine and Elmore Wonsley, were desperate for answers and sent the teen's body to Washington, D.C., for the private autopsy.

The official autopsy report from the State Medical Examiner's office in Mississippi is still pending, according to Jackson County Coroner Bruce Lynd Jr. Once that report is complete, it will be provided to the local coroner. "

The preliminary report for the private autopsy, which was commissioned by Wells' family, outlined several aspects of the body's condition that were "barriers to establishing a definitive cause and manner of death for Wells."

That report also noted that "the second autopsy performed on Nolan Wells revealed marked decompositional changes."

Additional dissections were performed, for which there were "no fractures or deep tissue injuries identified."

The preliminary report for the private autopsy also observed that during the initial autopsy in Mississippi, part of the throat was removed.

Doctors tell ABC News that it is not uncommon for pathologists to remove an organ or tissue to examine deeper inside the body. If a second autopsy is requested, there may be a

delay in the ability to examine the removed tissue. Factors like this can make secondary autopsies more difficult to conduct than the primary.

Crump said at the news conference that the independent pathologist also noted the significance of Wells' death occurring in or around a body of water; Wells could swim, but the circumstances surrounding his death are still not clear.

"With suspicion of drowning, it is important to confirm how that person entered the water," Crump said. "... At the time of this report, this forensic pathologist does not know the condition of Nolan Wells. He did not know whether he was conscious or unconscious when he entered the water -- he said that would be significant. He said he did not know whether he was forced into the water or unforced into the water -- he said that would be significant. So he said the condition of Nolan Wells before he entered the water would be the crux of the matter. It would be of utmost importance to being able to determine a cause and manner of death."

Crump also noted that "the original toxicology results have not been received at the time of this report." The toxicology report takes time and the official report has not yet been released.

The preliminary report for the private autopsy also noted an "area of red discoloration" in the back of Wells' head, but the report does not draw conclusions as to how the red discoloration occurred.

"Losing a child, it truly breaks your heart," Christine Wonsley said at Wednesday's news conference. "It is a pain that is, just, you can't measure it. Especially someone like Nolan, who brought so much joy and light and life to everyone."

"The only question we have is, what happened to our son?" she said.

Wells went missing on the 4th of July after going on a boat trip with friends to Horn Island,

according to authorities. It appears Wells stayed behind on the island after his friends left, officials said.

The college football player's body was recovered on July 6, and authorities said they suspect Wells drowned. Jackson County Sheriff John Ledbetter said there was no initial indication of a crime, but he stressed that investigators are "working diligently to determine exactly what occurred."

"Nolan Wells' family deserves a thorough and factual investigation, and that's exactly what they're going to get," he told ABC News last week.

Ledbetter also said the sheriff's office welcomes the family's independent investigation.

ABC News' Sabina Ghebremedhin and Deena Zaru contributed to this report.

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